

WHEN STEROIDS DON'T WORK

Your Cat's Compulsive Licking: The Guide That Actually Helps

A practical guide for cat owners whose cats won't stop licking, biting, or scratching themselves raw — and for whom standard allergy and steroid treatment hasn't worked.

PAGE 1 — COVER

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Your Cat's Compulsive Licking: The Guide That Actually Helps

For: Cat owners dealing with chronic feline self-grooming and skin self-trauma

PAGE 2 — INTRODUCTION

Your cat has a bald patch. Then a raw spot. Then blood.

You've been to the vet. Twice. Three times. They ran tests. They gave steroids — shots, then pills. They might have tried antibiotics. You changed the food. You bought the cone. The cat hated the cone. The spot came back the moment you took it off.

The vet says there's nothing wrong medically. The steroids aren't working. You're watching your cat hurt itself and you don't know what to try next.

This guide is for that moment.

It exists because the standard advice — "it's probably stress, try to reduce stress, maybe use a cone" — is not a plan. It's a hope. This guide is a plan.

What this guide covers:

Part 1 is a systematic medical checklist. Because "nothing is wrong" often means "we didn't look hard enough." In a published veterinary study, 76% of cats presenting with

what was initially called psychogenic alopecia — compulsive grooming with no obvious cause — had an identifiable medical trigger once proper diagnostics were done.

Part 2 covers the medication options beyond steroids, including what works when the corticosteroids have failed.

Part 3 is about reducing anxiety long-term, because even when medical causes are ruled out, the grooming habit has a neurological component that needs to be addressed.

What this guide does not cover: - Flea allergies (this guide assumes you've already addressed fleas and parasites) - General wellness or nutrition (this is a targeted guide for a specific crisis) - Kitten or young cat behaviors (compulsive grooming is primarily an adult cat issue)

If your cat has been licking the same spot raw for more than a few weeks, this guide is for you.

PAGE 3 — THE MEDICAL WORKUP CHECKLIST

Before you assume this is behavioral, run through this checklist. This is not optional — it is the foundation of everything else.

What "everything looks normal" actually means depends on what was tested.

If your vet did a physical exam and said "it looks fine, probably stress," and sent you home with steroids — that is not a complete workup. Demand the following:

Step 1: Urinalysis and Culture

Rules out: UTI, feline lower urinary tract disease (FLUTD)

FLUTD causes pain in the lower urinary tract. Cats often groom the groin, hind legs, or belly in response to that pain. A urinalysis detects blood, crystals, and infection. A culture identifies bacterial infection that may not show on routine dipstick.

This test is often skipped in grooming workups.

Step 2: Bloodwork + Thyroid Panel

Rules out: Hyperthyroidism, early kidney disease, diabetes

Hyperthyroidism is extremely common in cats over age 7. One of its symptoms is increased grooming. The standard thyroid panel (T4) is not always included in routine senior bloodwork. Ask for it specifically.

Early kidney disease causes pruritus (itching) in some cats. This is easy to miss if bloodwork is only evaluated for "sick" values rather than early-changes.

Step 3: Full Dermatologic Workup

Rules out: Demodicosis, dermatophytosis (ringworm), food allergies, environmental allergies

- Skin scrapings to rule out demodectic mange
- Fungal culture for ringworm (can be subclinical)
- At minimum: a structured flea trial (Advocate or similar, not just flea combing)

Step 4: Eight-to-Twelve-Week Food Elimination Trial

Rules out: Food allergy

This is the step most owners skip. Food allergy is a common cause of non-seasonal pruritus in cats. The trial requires feeding a novel protein or hydrolyzed protein diet exclusively — no treats, no table food, no flavored medications — for 8-12 weeks. If itching decreases during this period, you've found your answer.

Many owners say they "tried a different food for a few days." That is not a food trial.

Step 5: Dental Exam Under Sedation (If Mouth Grooming Is Present)

Rules out: Periodontal disease, FORL (tooth resorption), oral ulceration

Dental pain causes cats to groom the face and front paws obsessively. A conscious oral exam misses most pathology. Full-mouth radiographs under sedation are the standard of care for any cat with unexplained oral grooming.

Step 6: Abdominal Ultrasound (If GI Signs Are Present)

Rules out: IBD, intestinal lymphoma, pancreatitis

Inflammatory bowel disease causes chronic GI inflammation and pain. That pain can manifest as excessive grooming — often on the flanks or belly. If your cat has any history of vomiting, diarrhea, or weight changes, push for an abdominal ultrasound.

What This Checklist Should Tell You

If every test on this list comes back clean, then you are looking at a behavioral cause — true psychogenic alopecia. That's useful information. It means the steroids weren't going to help anyway, and it's time to shift strategy.

If even one item on this list wasn't done, you may not have the full picture. Go back to your vet with this checklist. A good vet will appreciate the specificity. If your vet refuses to run these tests, seek a second opinion or a veterinary dermatologist.

PAGE 4 — PILLAR 1 DEEP DIVE: TALKING TO YOUR VET ABOUT A COMPLETE WORKUP

How to Bring This Checklist to Your Vet

Start the conversation directly: "I'd like to rule out medical causes systematically before we treat this as a behavioral problem. Here's what I'm thinking we should check."

Most vets will respond well to this. It signals you're a motivated client, not a Google-educated skeptic. You're not challenging their competence — you're participating in your cat's care.

What to say:

"I've noticed [cat's name] has been licking [location] consistently for [X weeks/months]. The steroids helped briefly but it came back. Before we continue with medications for anxiety, I'd like to make sure we've done a complete medical workup. I'd like to request: urinalysis with culture, a thyroid panel, a food elimination trial, and a dermatology assessment. Can we set that up?"

What if your vet resists?

Some vets are reluctant to run extensive tests on a cat that "looks healthy." Be persistent. Quote the statistic: veterinary research shows 76% of cats with presumed

psychogenic alopecia had an identifiable medical cause. You are not asking for anything unusual — you are asking for a standard diagnostic process.

When to see a veterinary dermatologist:

If your general vet has run the tests above and found nothing, ask for a referral to a veterinary dermatologist. Dermatologists have access to intradermal allergy testing, advanced imaging, and more sophisticated diagnostic tools. They also have more experience with refractory cases.

The cost of a dermatology referral is significant (\$300-600 for the initial consult, plus diagnostics). But if your cat has been suffering for months and you're out of options, it is money well spent.

The 76% Statistic — What It Means for Your Cat

In a 21-cat study published in Veterinary Clinics of North America, researchers found that: - 76% of cats presenting with presumed psychogenic alopecia had an identifiable medical cause - 14% had both a medical cause and psychogenic alopecia - Only 10% were diagnosed with psychogenic alopecia alone

This is not a perfect study (21 cats is small), but it is consistent with clinical experience: most cases of unexplained feline grooming have an underlying physical cause that gets missed because the workup wasn't thorough enough.

Don't skip the tests.

PAGE 5 — MEDICATION OPTIONS WHEN STEROIDS HAVE FAILED

If the medical workup is clean, or if you've addressed the medical causes and the grooming persists, it's time to talk about medication. Steroids (corticosteroids) suppress the inflammatory response, but they don't address anxiety-driven compulsive behavior. For many cats, they simply don't work — or they work temporarily and then the grooming comes back the moment you reduce the dose.

Here are the medication options with the most evidence and clinical use:

Gabapentin — First-Line for Anxiety-Based Grooming

What it is: An anticonvulsant with well-documented anxiolytic properties in cats.

Typical dose: 10mg per kilogram of body weight, 2-3 times daily. Your vet will

determine the right dose. **What to expect:** - Mild to moderate sedation, especially in the first week - Reduced anxiety-driven behaviors within 3-5 days - Full effect at 2-4

weeks **Side effects:** Sedation, ataxia (wobbliness), rare GI upset **Notes:** Widely considered the safest and best-tolerated option for feline anxiety grooming. Can be compounded into a liquid for easier dosing.

Clonazepam — For the Anxiety Component

What it is: A benzodiazepine (same class as Valium) with anxiolytic and muscle relaxant properties. **Typical dose:** 0.5–1mg per cat, twice daily. **What to expect:** -

Reduction in anxiety-driven behaviors within days - Muscle relaxation that can interrupt the grooming-tension cycle **Side effects:** Sedation, increased appetite, potential for dependency with long-term use **Notes:** Not a first-choice for long-term use due to dependency concerns. Useful as a short-term bridge while other interventions (behavioral, environmental) take effect. Never stop clonazepam abruptly — taper under vet supervision.

Fluoxetine (Prozac) — For Severe or Long-Term Cases

What it is: An SSRI (selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor) used for anxiety and compulsive behaviors. **Typical dose:** 1–2mg per kilogram of body weight, once daily.

What to expect: - Takes 4–6 weeks for full behavioral effect - Reduces compulsive grooming intensity over time - May increase appetite initially **Side effects:** Initial

worsening of anxiety in first 1-2 weeks, sedation, GI effects **Notes:** This is a long-term medication, not a quick fix. If you use it, commit to at least 8 weeks before evaluating whether it's working. Fluoxetine is also used in humans — the compounded veterinary liquid form is typically unflavored and designed for cats.

Atopica (Cyclosporine) — For Allergy-Driven Grooming

What it is: An immunomodulatory medication used for atopic dermatitis. **What to expect:** - Reduces allergic itching and inflammation - Can reduce grooming driven by skin discomfort **Side effects:** GI upset is common; long-term monitoring required

Notes: Expensive. But if your cat's grooming has an allergic component that steroids

haven't controlled, this is a legitimate alternative.

What About CBD?

CBD products for cats are available, but the evidence base is thin. Some owners report benefit. The risk of unreliable formulations (many CBD products are mislabeled) is real. If you use CBD, use a product specifically formulated for cats, from a manufacturer with third-party testing. Discuss with your vet first — CBD can interact with other medications.

PAGE 6 — PILLAR 2 DEEP DIVE: PHYSICAL BARRIERS AND THEIR TRADE-OFFS

Medication addresses the internal drive. But while you're waiting for it to work — and while you're reducing anxiety through environmental changes — your cat is still licking. The skin won't heal if the cat keeps reopening it. Physical barriers are a necessary tool in the short to medium term.

The Traditional E-Collar: Necessary But Cruel for Some Cats

The plastic cone is the standard recommendation and it works — the cat physically cannot reach the spot. But many owners report that their cat:

- Refuses to eat or drink normally
- Bumps into walls and furniture
- Shows signs of profound stress
- Finds ways to remove it

If your cat is stressed to the point of panic by the cone, forcing it to wear one for weeks is not a reasonable solution. It stops the licking but creates a different problem.

Better Alternatives

Inflatable E-Collar A soft inflatable ring that goes around the neck. Less claustrophobic, allows better peripheral vision, easier to eat and sleep in. Available at most pet stores and online. Note: some determined cats can still reach their back legs and flank with these.

Recovery Suit (Cat Bodysuit) A fabric suit that covers the body. The cat can move freely, eat normally, and is protected from its own mouth. Recovery suits are available in multiple sizes and are machine washable. They take some getting used to, but most cats adapt within a day or two. This is often the best option for long-term use.

Mitten Socks / Paw Covers If your cat is specifically targeting its paws or legs, soft knit paw covers (sold as "cat mittens" or "claw guards") can prevent damage without restricting the whole body.

Bitter Apple Spray Topical deterrent sprays taste bad. Apply to the raw area (after confirming with your vet that the skin is healthy enough for topical products) to create a taste aversion. Not effective for all cats — some don't care about the taste — but worth trying. Use products specifically designed for cats.

Timing: How Long Do You Need Barriers?

The honest answer: as long as it takes for the skin to heal AND for the medication/enrichment to reduce the grooming drive.

For most cats: - Surface skin healing: 1–2 weeks if the cat can be prevented from licking
- Full fur regrowth: 4–8 weeks - Behavioral change (medication effect): 2–6 weeks

Plan for at least 4 weeks of barrier use. Don't take the cone off after 3 days because the spot "looks better." The grooming habit has a neurological component that takes weeks to weaken.

PAGE 7 — ENVIRONMENTAL ENRICHMENT: THE ANXIETY REDUCTION PROTOCOL

Medication and barriers buy time. Enrichment addresses the root cause: chronic feline anxiety.

Cats are not low-maintenance pets. They are obligate hunters with strong territorial instincts. A cat that is anxious or under-stimulated will find ways to self-soothe — and for some cats, that means grooming to the point of self-harm.

The goal is to reduce baseline anxiety by meeting your cat's core behavioral needs.

The Hunt-Catch-Kill-Eat Cycle (2-3 Times Daily)

Cats are built for predation. When they can't hunt, they become anxious. A 10-minute wand toy session lets your cat complete the predatory sequence — stalk, chase, pounce, catch, "kill" — and produces genuine stress relief.

How to do it: - Use a wand toy with a prey-like attachment (feather, fur, fabric) - Drag it erratically to simulate prey movement - Let your cat catch and "kill" it at the end - End with a treat so the sequence completes

Two to three sessions per day is the target. Even one is better than none. If you work full time, do one session in the morning and two in the evening.

Food Puzzles — Feed the Brain

Replace or supplement bowl feeding with puzzle feeders. A cat that works for its food uses mental energy and experiences lower stress.

Options by budget: - **Free:** Toilet paper rolls folded at both ends with holes punched in them - **\$5-15:** Classic puzzle feeders (Cat It, Trixie) - **\$15-30:** Advanced puzzles (Doc Phoebe's, Nina Ottosson)

For a cat that's already stressed, start easy and increase difficulty gradually.

Vertical Space

Cats feel safer off the ground. Cat trees, wall-mounted shelves, window perches, and tall furniture give your cat a sense of territorial control.

Minimum: one cat tree or tall shelf near a window. In multi-cat homes: provide multiple vertical resources so cats don't have to share.

Feliway Classic (Pheromone Diffuser)

Feliway mimics feline facial pheromones — the ones cats deposit when they rub their face against familiar objects. It signals safety and territory. Multiple clinical studies support its use for stress-related feline behaviors.

Plug the diffuser in the room where your cat spends the most time. One diffuser covers approximately 500-700 square feet. Replace the refill every 4-6 weeks.

Feliway Friends is the multi-cat formulation. If you have more than one cat in the household, use Feliway Friends.

Multi-Cat Household Assessment

Inter-cat tension is a direct anxiety driver. Watch for: - Staring at each other across rooms - Chasing (one cat chasing another is conflict, not play) - Blocking access to litter boxes, food, or resting spots - One cat hiding while another roams freely

The resource rule: One litter box per cat plus one extra, placed in different locations. Separate feeding stations. Multiple resting spots at different heights. If cats can't see each other while eating, that's better.

Routine

Cats are creatures of routine. Feeding at the same time every day, consistent play times, and predictable environmental schedules reduce baseline anxiety significantly.

If you've recently moved, introduced a new pet or baby, or changed your schedule, that disruption may be a grooming trigger. Try to re-establish consistent daily routines.

PAGE 8 — PILLAR 3 DEEP DIVE: WHAT TO EXPECT IN THE FIRST SIX WEEKS

Week 1-2: Tests, Barriers, Baseline

- Complete or schedule the medical workup from Page 3
- Start any prescribed medication (gabapentin typically starts within days)
- Begin using physical barriers if raw skin is present
- Start one structured play session per day
- Set up Feliway diffuser

Expect limited improvement. This is the setup phase.

Week 2-3: First Medication Effects

- If gabapentin: anxiety reduction should be noticeable
- If steroids were the previous treatment: you may see them being tapered off
- Skin should begin to heal if barriers are working
- Monitor for medication side effects

If you see no reduction in grooming drive after 2 weeks on a new medication, talk to your vet about adjusting dose or switching medications.

Week 3-4: Skin Healing and Behavior Tracking

- Raw spots should be visibly healing if barriers are consistently in place
- Fur regrowth (small) may be visible at bald patches
- Log daily grooming behavior — is it decreasing? Same spot or new spots?

- Increase play sessions to 2 per day if possible

Week 4-6: Consolidation

- Medication dose should be at maintenance level
- Environmental enrichment should be fully in place
- Fur regrowth visible on most cats
- Watch for relapse triggers: missed medication doses, changes in routine, new stressors

When Things Get Worse Before They Get Better

Some cats groom more in the first 1-2 weeks of a new medication before improving. This is not unusual — especially with SSRIs like fluoxetine, which can initially increase anxiety. Don't stop the medication without talking to your vet.

What About Relapse?

Compulsive grooming can recur when: - Medication is stopped too early - Environmental stressors change (new home, new pet, baby) - Underlying medical condition (IBD, allergy) flares - You remove barriers before the behavior is fully extinguished

When relapse happens, go back to the toolkit: barriers, medication, enrichment. Most cats can get back to baseline with the same protocol.

PAGE 9 — QUICK-REFERENCE CHECKLIST

Medical Workup Checklist

- ☐ Urinalysis with culture
- ☐ Bloodwork: CBC + chemistry + thyroid panel (T4)
- ☐ Dermatologic workup: skin scrapings, fungal culture, flea trial
- ☐ Food elimination trial: 8-12 weeks, novel or hydrolyzed protein
- ☐ Dental exam under sedation (if face/paw grooming)
- ☐ Abdominal ultrasound (if GI signs present)

Medication Comparison

Medication	Type	Onset	Key Side Effect	Best For
Gabapentin	Anticonvulsant/anxiolytic	3-5 days	Sedation	First-line anxiety grooming
Clonazepam	Benzodiazepine	1-2 days	Sedation, dependency risk	Short-term bridge use
Fluoxetine	SSRI	4-6 weeks	Initial anxiety spike	Long-term severe cases
Atopica	Immunomodulator	2-4 weeks	GI upset	Allergy-driven grooming

Daily Enrichment Schedule

- ☐ Morning: 5-10 min wand toy play session
- ☐ Evening: 5-10 min wand toy play session
- ☐ At least one meal from puzzle feeder
- ☐ Feliway diffuser running
- ☐ Fresh water available

Weekly Assessment

- ☐ Is raw skin healing? (Take a photo on Day 1 to compare)
- ☐ Is grooming frequency decreasing?
- ☐ Any new spots appearing?
- ☐ Is medication being given consistently?
- ☐ Any new stressors introduced this week?

Barrier Options Ranked by Cat Adaptability

1. Recovery suit (best for long-term use)
2. Inflatable e-collar (moderate restriction)
3. Traditional cone (effective but stressful for many cats)

PAGE 10 — NEXT STEPS

Your Bonus: Included

This guide comes with a free companion checklist — the quick-reference checklist from Page 9 in a printable format, designed to hang on your fridge or keep near your cat's supplies.

Your Bonus: Included — available in your Lemon Squeezy library.

What to Do Right Now

1. **Book the vet appointment.** Use the checklist on Page 3 to request a complete workup. If your vet resists, get a second opinion.
2. **Start the barriers.** If your cat has raw skin, don't wait. Get a recovery suit or inflatable e-collar today.
3. **Get the medication.** If your vet agrees this is anxiety-driven, gabapentin is the most accessible starting point.
4. **Start one play session per day.** Today, if possible. Five minutes with a wand toy is not optional enrichment — it's as essential as food.
5. **Download the free checklist.** Keep it where you feed your cat. Track progress daily.

Where to Get the Full Guide + More Help

For new customers: Your complete guide and all future updates are available in your Lemon Squeezy library — click the link in your order confirmation email.

For existing customers: Everything is already in your Member's Area, along with additional resources and the printable companion checklist.

Your Bonus: Included — available in your Lemon Squeezy library.

This guide is for educational purposes and does not replace veterinary care. Always consult a licensed veterinarian for diagnosis and treatment of your cat's health conditions.